

Engelsk C

Collected Texts

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Chapter I

Voice

Have You Heard of Oscar Wilde?

Stephen Fry

2012

I grew up in the country, deep in the country. The nearest major library was a twelve-mile bicycle ride into the city of Norwich. I was lucky to live in a house filled with books and to have parents who loved to read, but by the time I approached teenage my appetite for reading, combined with my more or less chronic insomnia, meant that I needed more, far
5 more books to consume daily. Every other Thursday, a mobile library (in the form of a large grey pantechicon that would today look absurdly old-fashioned) would come along and park not five minutes' walk from our house. This was my lifeline to the outside world. A quaint battleship-grey modem that linked me to the huge past and present that seemed so impossibly far from the lanes of rural Norfolk.

10 Aged eleven, one Saturday afternoon I sat in front of our little black and white television set (despite the glowering disapproval of my father who thought – quite rightly of course – that television was a vulgar and despicable thing and that no healthy child should watch it, especially during the hours of sunlight) and watched breathless with enthralled disbelief as they screened a film directed by Anthony 'Puffin' Asquith. It was called The Importance of
15 Being Earnest and it left me simply boggling with excitement. I had never heard language used in such a way, had never known that the rhythms of a sentence could be so beautiful, that meanings could turn with such wit on the hinge of a 'but' or an 'unless' – in short I had never known that writing could do more than tell a story, that it could excite in the way that music does. I remembered whole lines of dialogue and repeated them: phrases like 'I hope,
20 Cecily, I shall not offend you if I state quite frankly and openly that you seem to me to be in every way the visible personification of absolute perfection' and 'some aunts are tall, some aunts are not tall. That is a matter that surely an aunt may be allowed to decide for herself'. I hugged these to me as I watched the credits roll by and memorised a name.

The following Thursday I ran to the corner of the lane and threw myself inside the mobile
25 library the moment the door at the rear had opened and the steps been let down. 'Have you heard of Oscar Wilde?' I squealed to the cardiganed librarian within who clutched her beads in alarm at the urgency and intensity of my attack. 'Goodness me, young man ...' 'Do you have a play he wrote called The Importance of Being Earnest?' 'Well now ...' 'Please, I have to read it!' After what seemed an age we found a copy which was duly stamped. I ran home
30 and up the stairs and into my bedroom.

I read The Importance of Being Earnest three or four times a day every day for two weeks. Then I returned it. I knew the whole play off by heart and can still distress companions with long quotations from it. 'What else do you have by Oscar Wilde?' I wanted to know. It was a different librarian and she found me a copy of the Complete Works.

35 Two weeks later I was back to have it restamped. I had read it from cover to cover, but I wanted to read it all again and again.

Another Library Thursday came and I reluctantly returned the Complete Works and asked if there was anything else by Oscar Wilde I could read. 'The Complete Works means the com-

plete works,' the librarian explained. 'Oh but there must be something else ...' The librarian
40 gave a sigh and then looked me up and down. 'I'm not sure ... but there is ...' 'Yes? Yes?' She
walked along the central corridor of the van and stooped low in the biography section ... her
face was flushed as she straightened and placed a book uncertainly into my hands. 'I really
don't know if ... how old are you, young man?' 'Thirteen,' I lied. It was an age that seemed
impossibly mature. 'Well ...' The book was called *The Trials of Oscar Wilde* and was written
45 by someone called H. Montgomery Hyde.

I took it home and read it. It was a book that changed my life. The heroic lord of language
who had captivated me so entirely turned out to have had a secret life. And the more I read
the faster my heart beat. For I knew that I shared the same secret. I had never quite dared tell
myself this truth but reading of Wilde's arrest and trial I could not but know it to be true.

50 It was shattering, terrible, liberating, stimulating, appalling, wonderful and incredible all at
once.

The mobile library a fortnight later had nothing more to offer so the following morning I
caught a little motor coach early in the morning and went to Norwich. There in Esperanto
Way stood the city's great library, since burned in a fire and replaced by a fine one complete
55 with cafés and all kinds of modern excitements.

It was here that I discovered how one book could lead one to another. Bibliographies and
footnotes suggested new names, new books, new writers, whole new areas to be discovered.
It was an analogue card-indexed way of mouse-clicking from one link to another. A little
more laborious perhaps, but breathlessly exciting.

60 Over the next few years the trial and trail of Oscar had led me to read Gide and Genet, Auden
and Orton, Norman Douglas and Ronald Firbank. Unforgettable, transformative books for
me were that same H. Montgomery Hyde's *The Other Love*, Roger Peyrefitte's *The Exile of
Capri and Special Friendships*, Angus Stewart's *Sandel* and Michael Campbell's *Lord Dis-
miss Us*. I read of man-love, boy-love and free love. I clutched to myself the dark secrets of
65 the infamous Book 13 of the Greek Anthology and the Venice letters in *Quest for Corvo*. I
read Cuthbert Worsley's *Flannelled Fool* and Robin Maugham's *Escape from the Shadows*.
From over the Atlantic I encountered Gore Vidal and John Rechy. I discovered the Tangier
set, by way of Michael Davies, Paul Bowles, William Burroughs and dozens of others.

70 For a gay youth growing up in the early '70s a library was a way of showing that I was not
alone. There was an element of titillation and breath-taking possibility, even the chance of a
fumbled encounter, but there was vindication too. Some of the best, finest, truest, cleverest
minds that ever held a pen in their hands had been like me.

It was almost a side-effect that this caused me to educate myself to a degree which was be-
yond anything a school could hope to achieve. My own appetite for knowledge and reading
75 and connection had led me, and that is how education works, not by spoon-feeding, but
by stimulating the appetite so that children cannot wait to feed themselves. Between the
ages of twelve and fourteen I read hundreds and hundreds of books, but more importantly I
became unafraid of reading. Great Writers, I discovered, were not to be bowed down before
and worshipped, but embraced and befriended. Their names resounded through history not
80 because they had massive brows and thought deep incomprehensible thoughts, but because
they opened windows in the mind, they put their arms round you and showed you things
you always knew but never dared to believe. Even if their names were terrifyingly foreign
and intellectual-sounding, Dostoevsky, Baudelaire or Cavafy, they turned out to be charm-
ing and wonderful and quite unalarming after all. Late Henry James was a struggle, I will

85 confess, and some of the longer sentences in Proust would lose me entirely, but all in all, by the time I was fourteen I knew that being gay was a kind of dark blessing, an awful privilege and I knew that, as Oscar once wrote on a photograph to an admirer, 'The secret of life is in art.'

Without libraries none of this would have been possible. They are still to me places of incredible glamour, possibility, power, excitement and pleasure. Of course the world wide web and the wonders of the digital age, as well as advances in social understanding, decency and common sense make it less likely that a gay teenager need ever grow up feeling alone, but the downside to that huge advance is that that same teenager may never be led to those magical municipal labyrinths whose shelves contain so much and the existence of which for 95 the better part of two hundred years has so immeasurably improved the quality for so many millions of ordinary lives.

How th'Irth Wint Rong by Hapless Joey@homeskool.guv

Gregory Maguire

2013

OK OK.

I am riting on this paper the old-timey way with a pen. This is my 5st copy and the last copy. Its no good I dont care. Kick me outa homeskool, what happens, Im alreddy home. Ha ha.

- The Big Ant says OK OK git to work buster. Very funnish start but wut about yor topic title?
- 5 How th'Irth Wint Rong. Tell me wut you has to tell, says the Big Ant. Hoo wins th'essay contist gits a hole ham for the wintir. Go for it, Hapless Joey. Yu needs it, yor wasting away, I kin see yor ribs thru yor parka. I kin see yor thinkings thru yor hairliss skalp. Yu gits ideers fast enuff. Put yor mind on the paje.

OK OK.

- 10 Big Ant sits and luks at papers from othr kids. Looks at papers. Im not riting this over. She sits herself up by th'stove nere the best hot part. She says she kint unnerstand a singul wird of wut she is lukiing at. I got to git myself unnerstud.

Topic title: How th'Irth Wint Rong by Hapless Joey @ homeskool.guv

- (Big Ant says, that last bit. Homeskool dot guv. Thats fake. Britetime writing. From back in the days of internet and puters. Take it out she says. I dont. I think it looks cool. Maybe
- 15 puters will be invented again. Sum day. Besides, she not suppoz to tell me stuff. Thay want to see how I kin think for my self.)

I am Hapless Joey. I am not a liddle kid. I am not a groanup. I am tall as th'pegs for cotes in th'halfway. I waz liddle wonce now I'm not so mutch.

- 20 I liv in a shack. Hoo dont, yu say but lots dont. My dore gots a lock an my winders gots glass. I im here with my grandid Ole Joey an sometimes Big Ant come over. She suppoz to be fare but this hous is not so windy and cold as some so I gits mor uv hir time. That's wy I cin rite so gud. Good. Big Ant is good teecher but she eets a lot. She's Big Ant. She gots to close hir coat with a rope. Lurning me to rite makes hir hungerful I gess. Me to.

- 25 Note to Commity: This is Big Ant and I have no intrist in a ham or in getting out of the stupid bone-chilling cold. Hapless Joey has some wits about him so pay attention to what he says. Im not allowed to correct his work but I cant stand by and let him slag me off without pitching a comment about it. His house aint all that warm neither.

- Also I aint that big, just got a big heart as any Sinner will tell you and a big heart needs a big
- 30 rib cage to hold it and stout legs to stand it up and walk it about. I only use a rope around my coat becawse a dog cawt my belt onct when I was walking home with a chicken curry courtesy of Sector Admin. who admire my work with kids by the way.

I waz born a short time befor the Cold Time startd. My grandid tells me all the time abowt the wirlt then. Its hard to beleve wut he says. I cint member I wuz a baby. But them pickchrs
35 in buks books bux whatever, thay dont lie. I seen cars withowt rust an I seen green yards like blankets put down. The grass green awl so smooth. I seen a sky with no clowds, awl sweet an blu lik the cleanest sheet yu ever seen. In pickchrs I seen it, torn from books an handg up in th Pickchr Plase calld the Multiplecks.

Back then th'Irth was fuller. More warm. More cleen. Peepul culd fly arownd in metal rumez
40 with wings an go here an there. Over to Yurup an Japan an Afrika. An other playcis that uzed to exist. Thay culd go and cum back like eezy peezy wuts the problem? Thay culd go on big ships ovir the water. Thay culd liv in Parisfrants or in Lundininglind or in Romittly. Thay dint think nuthin uv it, thay just livd like you an me. Well bettr then you an me becaws that wuz befor th'Irthsore happin.

45 The Big Ant says OK OK I got to rite abowt th'Irthsore. Thass my hole point. Th'Irthsore that chaynjd the wirlt. That made Cold Time.

Back wen my parints wer yung an just chirchd, thay was a mom an a dad too, just like in sum of them pickshrs, th'Irth it wuz cleen and all ficksed up. Cars slid up and forth the streets. Sinners culd tawk on littl metel cards with numbrs on them. Thru th'air I meen,
50 like if you had a frend in Berlinjerminey or Athnsgrese you just like sed sum numbrs and they sed sum numbrs back an it was like, Hi, how ar you, how is it over there in Parisfrantz or Kieroejipt. Evrybuddy did it all the time like it wuz nuthing spexial. Speshul. Spejal. Nuthing unyoujewel.

Note to Commity: This is Big Ant again an you see a brake here in the story because Hapless
55 Joey smashed his pencil in distress. He spells better than most but that dont mean nothing to him. He wants to get it write. Thats what marks him owt for spexhul notice. I told him stop with bragging all those cities, theys all gone and you do yourself no favors reminding the Commity so he stopps. But he likes geogriphy and maps as you can see so planely. He started writing agin a few days later. Its with a color pencil but its still his work. He is good
60 dont you agree.

I dont member enny uv this. Th'Irth before Coldtime. Its mor like a dreem sumbuddy have. But Grandid and Big Ant member fine an others to. Two. Too.

Grandid uze to go to liberry, an it uze to be free. Also opin. He culd reed most anything he wantd to. He unnerstands sum uv wat happind. He told me an now I im telling yu. Ywo.
65 Yoo

Damm damm damm. I hate spelling its not lawful.

OK OK. I im bettr now.

Here is wat happind. Back then th'Irth wuz pirfect an men had jobs an cash and womin had soft yello hair an didnt need so many cotes. Thay culdn feel the cold I gess. It wuz a time
70 of heros an moving stars on th'Irth. Grandid livd then so did Big Ant. So did my parints. Th'Irth wen I git born wuz still paradize only nobuddy new it wuz.

With awl the big masheens an stuff life wuz eezy an warm an lots uv food. An pepul culd go arownd the wirlt to plases like Nirobiafrika. An China an Oztrailya.

The peepul all think thay is smartr than God. Thay make a mashine in the mowntens be-
75 twene France an Switzrland. It is big it is ugly it is powrfull. It makes the motes in God's eye go fastr an fastr in a big tunnl a hunderd miles long. A sircul tunnl, rownd an rownd. Peepul

call'd Siontists thay study the spede uv the parts. The dust uv the wírl'd. The smithireens uv the planet. The motes uv God's eye. Wow thay say wow, wow! wow! We make the crums an bits uv the wírl'd run fastr.

80 Wy du thay do this yu ask. Its a gud kwestchun. I do not no the anser.

Then wun day God gits mad at peepul playing with th'Irth. The peepul spin the motes so fast rownd and rownd thay meet themselvs coming the othr way. God lets it happn. God lets the durt in the tunnl hit itself. Hard. Thass wat peepul now think. I wuz only a baby but Grandid says he woke up during th'Irthsore an the hole morning was braking up lik threds on the edj uv a carpit.

85 It wuz 6 in the morning an he culd see me in my crib in the morning lite. My hands wir trying to clap but thay culdnt. Evrything in the wírl'd wuz pulling to wun side. Like static lectrisity back wen thay had lectrisity. My baby hand an the crib an the winder wir awl pulling. Brok up into eech othr. Lik meltd mud an snow an crud draggd awl wun way by a stick with fings. 90 Grandids legs an the sheets wir awl pulling like taffy an he culdnt moove to git me. It stayd lik that for an owr or so then it pool'd back to normil.

But it wuz not the same normil. Maybe an owr or maybe time got pulld too.

Thay sed on the streets that the big tunnl cullapsd. Maebe it made a nu kind uv dust that dint like th'Irth. Or maebe it made a tiny mowth in th'Irth that wuz hungry an wantd to 95 eet th'Irth. Or it wuz maebe spots uv Nothing an it dissolv'd th'Irth as far as it culd. But Nothing cant exist by itself or nobuddy wuld notiss it, says the Chirch Man. Nothing ate the haff of th'Irth that wuz on that side. Wen it finish'd haff it tride to go on but th othr haff of Nothing is Sumthing. It was ar haff of th'Irth so we stayd Sumthing.

The othr haff the dark haff is Nothing. No wun unnerstands wut is in it Nothing I gess. 100 Haff a planit uv Sumthing, haff a planit uv Nothing. Pirfect balans.

Just darck. Darck Nothing.

Why is that I wunder.

OK OK. The end.

Note to Commity: Now you see what I am trying to show you. Hapless Joey is a good boy 105 and he knows a lot. This is the best pece of riting I seen in four or five years. I think you shuld also know that his parents were in Moscow or someplace when the SuperCollider collapsed. Like half the wírl'd they never been hird from again.

It is my belief he deserve the ham. I culd come get it just give the say-so.

Dear Big Ant, The Committee has reviewed the writing of Hapless Joey and agrees with you 110 that he is special material. Will you bring him to Central next week, any day you like, and we will train him up to be a missile into the Dark Edge. We have only sent ten or twelve people in ten years, and one day one of them will come back and tell us what they found there. Hapless Joey may be the lucky one. His name is the opposite of lucky, and something is the opposite of nothing. Don't tell Hapless Joey what he has won. He may need to grow up more to 115 appreciate the honor. We don't want him to run away. You may keep the ham for yourself after you give him up.

The Doll's House

Katherine Mansfield

1922

When dear old Mrs. Hay went back to town after staying with the Burnells she sent the children a doll's house. It was so big that the carter and Pat carried it into the courtyard, and there it stayed, propped up on two wooden boxes beside the feed-room door. No harm could come to it; it was summer. And perhaps the smell of paint would have gone off by the time
5 it had to be taken in. For, really, the smell of paint coming from that doll's house ("Sweet of old Mrs. Hay, of course; most sweet and generous!") – but the smell of paint was quite enough to make anyone seriously ill, in Aunt Beryl's opinion. Even before the sacking was taken off. And when it was ...

There stood the doll's house, a dark, oily, spinach green, picked out with bright yellow. Its
10 two solid little chimneys, glued on to the roof, were painted red and white, and the door, gleaming with yellow varnish, was like a little slab of toffee. Four windows, real windows, were divided into panes by a broad streak of green. There was actually a tiny porch, too, painted yellow, with big lumps of congealed paint hanging along the edge.

But perfect, perfect little house! Who could possibly mind the smell. It was part of the joy,
15 part of the newness.

"Open it quickly, someone!"

The hook at the side was stuck fast. Pat pried it open with his penknife, and the whole house front swung back, and – there you were, gazing at one and the same moment into the drawing-room and dining-room, the kitchen and two bedrooms. That is the way for a
20 house to open! Why don't all houses open like that? How much more exciting than peering through the slit of a door into a mean little hall with a hatstand and two umbrellas! That is – isn't it? – what you long to know about a house when you put your hand on the knocker. Perhaps it is the way God opens houses at the dead of night when He is taking a quiet turn with an angel ...

"O-oh!" The Burnell children sounded as though they were in despair. It was too marvellous; it was too much for them. They had never seen anything like it in their lives. All the rooms were papered. There were pictures on the walls, painted on the paper, with gold frames complete. Red carpet covered all the floors except the kitchen; red plush chairs in the drawing-room, green in the dining-room; tables, beds with real bedclothes, a cradle, a stove, a dresser
30 with tiny plates and one big jug. But what Kezia liked more than anything, what she liked frightfully, was the lamp. It stood in the middle of the dining-room table, an exquisite little amber lamp with a white globe. It was even filled all ready for lighting though, of course, you couldn't light it. But there was something inside that looked like oil and moved when you shook it.

35 The father and mother dolls, who sprawled very stiff as though they had fainted in the drawing-room, and their two little children asleep upstairs, were really too big for the doll's house.

They didn't look as though they belonged. But the lamp was perfect. It seemed to smile at Kezia, to say, "I live here." The lamp was real.

40 The Burnell children could hardly walk to school fast enough the next morning. They burned to tell everybody, to describe, to – well – to boast about their doll's house before the school-bell rang.

"I'm to tell," said Isabel, "because I'm the eldest. And you two can join in after. But I'm to tell first."

45 There was nothing to answer. Isabel was bossy, but she was always right, and Lottie and Kezia knew too well the powers that went with being eldest. They brushed through the thick buttercups at the road edge and said nothing.

"And I'm to choose who's to come and see it first. Mother said I might."

50 For it had been arranged that while the doll's house stood in the courtyard they might ask the girls at school, two at a time, to come and look. Not to stay to tea, of course, or to come traipsing through the house. But just to stand quietly in the courtyard while Isabel pointed out the beauties, and Lottie and Kezia looked pleased ...

55 But hurry as they might, by the time they had reached the tarred palings of the boys' playground the bell had begun to jangle. They only just had time to whip off their hats and fall into line before the roll was called. Never mind. Isabel tried to make up for it by looking very important and mysterious and by whispering behind her hand to the girls near her, "Got something to tell you at playtime."

60 Playtime came and Isabel was surrounded. The girls of her class nearly fought to put their arms round her, to walk away with her, to beam flatteringly, to be her special friend. She held quite a court under the huge pine trees at the side of the playground. Nudging, giggling together, the little girls pressed up close. And the only two who stayed outside the ring were the two who were always outside, the little Kelveys. They knew better than to come anywhere near the Burnells.

65 For the fact was, the school the Burnell children went to was not at all the kind of place their parents would have chosen if there had been any choice. But there was none. It was the only school for miles. And the consequence was all the children of the neighbourhood, the judge's little girls, the doctor's daughters, the store-keeper's children, the milkman's, were forced to mix together. Not to speak of there being an equal number of rude, rough little boys as well. But the line had to be drawn somewhere. It was drawn at the Kelveys. Many of the children, including the Burnells, were not allowed even to speak to them. They walked past 70 the Kelveys with their heads in the air, and as they set the fashion in all matters of behaviour, the Kelveys were shunned by everybody. Even the teacher had a special voice for them, and a special smile for the other children when Lil Kelvey came up to her desk with a bunch of dreadfully common-looking flowers.

75 They were the daughters of a spry, hardworking little washerwoman, who went about from house to house by the day. This was awful enough. But where was Mr. Kelvey? Nobody knew for certain. But everybody said he was in prison. So they were the daughters of a washerwoman and a gaolbird. Very nice company for other people's children! And they looked it. Why Mrs. Kelvey made them so conspicuous was hard to understand. The truth was they were dressed in 'bits' given to her by the people for whom she worked. Lil, for instance, 80 who was a stout, plain child, with big freckles, came to school in a dress made from a green art-erge table-cloth of the Burnells, with red plush sleeves from the Logans' curtains. Her

hat, perched on top of her high forehead, was a grown-up woman's hat, once the property of Miss Lecky, the postmistress. It was turned up at the back and trimmed with a large scarlet quill. What a little guy she looked! It was impossible not to laugh. And her little sister, our
85 Else, wore a long white dress, rather like a nightgown, and a pair of little boy's boots. But whatever our Else wore she would have looked strange. She was a tiny wishbone of a child, with cropped hair and enormous solemn eyes – a little white owl. Nobody had ever seen her smile; she scarcely ever spoke. She went through life holding on to Lil, with a piece of Lil's skirt screwed up in her hand. Where Lil went, our Else followed. In the playground, on
90 the road going to and from school, there was Lil marching in front and our Else holding on behind. Only when she wanted anything, or when she was out of breath, our Else gave Lil a tug, a twitch, and Lil stopped and turned round. The Kelveys never failed to understand each other.

Now they hovered at the edge; you couldn't stop them listening. When the little girls turned
95 round and sneered, Lil, as usual, gave her silly, shamefaced smile, but our Else only looked.

And Isabel's voice, so very proud, went on telling. The carpet made a great sensation, but so did the beds with real bedclothes, and the stove with an oven door.

When she finished Kezia broke in. "You've forgotten the lamp, Isabel."

"Oh, yes," said Isabel, "and there's a teeny little lamp, all made of yellow glass, with a white
100 globe that stands on the dining-room table. You couldn't tell it from a real one."

"The lamp's best of all," cried Kezia. She thought Isabel wasn't making half enough of the little lamp. But nobody paid any attention. Isabel was choosing the two who were to come back with them that afternoon and see it. She chose Emmie Cole and Lena Logan. But when the others knew they were all to have a chance, they couldn't be nice enough to Isabel. One
105 by one they put their arms round Isabel's waist and walked her off. They had something to whisper to her, a secret. "Isabel's my friend."

Only the little Kelveys moved away forgotten; there was nothing more for them to hear.

Days passed, and as more children saw the doll's house, the fame of it spread. It became the one subject, the rage. The one question was, "Have you seen Burnells' doll's house? Oh,
110 ain't it lovely?" "Haven't you seen it? Oh, I say!"

Even the dinner hour was given up to talking about it. The little girls sat under the pines eating their thick mutton sandwiches and big slabs of johnny cake spread with butter. While always, as near as they could get, sat the Kelveys, our Else holding on to Lil, listening too, while they chewed their jam sandwiches out of a newspaper soaked with large red blobs ...

115 "Mother," said Kezia, "can't I ask the Kelveys just once?"

"Certainly not, Kezia."

"But why not?"

"Run away, Kezia; you know quite well why not."

At last everybody had seen it except them. On that day the subject rather flagged. It was the
120 dinner hour. The children stood together under the pine trees, and suddenly, as they looked at the Kelveys eating out of their paper, always by themselves, always listening, they wanted to be horrid to them. Emmie Cole started the whisper.

"Lil Kelvey's going to be a servant when she grows up."

“O-oh, how awful!” said Isabel Burnell, and she made eyes at Emmie.

125 Emmie swallowed in a very meaning way and nodded to Isabel as she’d seen her mother do on those occasions.

“It’s true – it’s true – it’s true,” she said.

Then Lena Logan’s little eyes snapped. “Shall I ask her?” she whispered.

“Bet you don’t,” said Jessie May.

130 “Pooh, I’m not frightened,” said Lena. Suddenly she gave a little squeal and danced in front of the other girls. “Watch! Watch me! Watch me now!” said Lena. And sliding, gliding, dragging one foot, giggling behind her hand, Lena went over to the Kelveys.

Lil looked up from her dinner. She wrapped the rest quickly away. Our Else stopped chewing. What was coming now? “Is it true you’re going to be a servant when you grow up, Lil Kelvey?” shrilled Lena.

135 Dead silence. But instead of answering, Lil only gave her silly, shamefaced smile. She didn’t seem to mind the question at all. What a sell for Lena! The girls began to titter.

Lena couldn’t stand that. She put her hands on her hips; she shot forward. “Yah, yer father’s in prison!” she hissed, spitefully.

140 This was such a marvellous thing to have said that the little girls rushed away in a body, deeply, deeply excited, wild with joy. Someone found a long rope, and they began skipping. And never did they skip so high, run in and out so fast, or do such daring things as on that morning.

In the afternoon Pat called for the Burnell children with the buggy and they drove home.

145 There were visitors. Isabel and Lottie, who liked visitors, went upstairs to change their pinafores. But Kezia thieved out at the back. Nobody was about; she began to swing on the big white gates of the courtyard. Presently, looking along the road, she saw two little dots. They grew bigger, they were coming towards her. Now she could see that one was in front and one close behind. Now she could see that they were the Kelveys. Kezia stopped swinging. She slipped

150 off the gate as if she was going to run away. Then she hesitated. The Kelveys came nearer, and beside them walked their shadows, very long, stretching right across the road with their heads in the buttercups. Kezia clambered back on the gate; she had made up her mind; she swung out.

“Hullo,” she said to the passing Kelveys.

155 They were so astounded that they stopped. Lil gave her silly smile. Our Else stared.

“You can come and see our doll’s house if you want to,” said Kezia, and she dragged one toe on the ground. But at that Lil turned red and shook her head quickly.

“Why not?” asked Kezia.

Lil gasped, then she said, “Your ma told our ma you wasn’t to speak to us.”

160 “Oh, well,” said Kezia. She didn’t know what to reply. “It doesn’t matter. You can come and see our doll’s house all the same. Come on. Nobody’s looking.”

But Lil shook her head still harder.

“Don’t you want to?” asked Kezia.

165 Suddenly there was a twitch, a tug at Lil's skirt. She turned round. Our Else was looking at her with big, imploring eyes; she was frowning; she wanted to go. For a moment Lil looked at our Else very doubtfully. But then our Else twitched her skirt again. She started forward. Kezia led the way. Like two little stray cats they followed across the courtyard to where the doll's house stood.

"There it is," said Kezia.

170 There was a pause. Lil breathed loudly, almost snorted; our Else was still as stone. "I'll open it for you," said Kezia kindly. She undid the hook and they looked inside. "There's the drawing-room and the dining-room, and that's the –"

"Kezia!"

Oh, what a start they gave!

175 "Kezia!"

It was Aunt Beryl's voice. They turned round. At the back door stood Aunt Beryl, staring as if she couldn't believe what she saw.

180 "How dare you ask the little Kelveys into the courtyard?" said her cold, furious voice. "You know as well as I do, you're not allowed to talk to them. Run away, children, run away at once. And don't come back again," said Aunt Beryl. And she stepped into the yard and shooed them out as if they were chickens.

"Off you go immediately!" she called, cold and proud.

185 They did not need telling twice. Burning with shame, shrinking together, Lil huddling along like her mother, our Else dazed, somehow they crossed the big courtyard and squeezed through the white gate.

"Wicked, disobedient little girl!" said Aunt Beryl bitterly to Kezia, and she slammed the doll's house to.

190 The afternoon had been awful. A letter had come from Willie Brent, a terrifying, threatening letter, saying if she did not meet him that evening in Pulman's Bush, he'd come to the front door and ask the reason why! But now that she had frightened those little rats of Kelveys and given Kezia a good scolding, her heart felt lighter. That ghastly pressure was gone. She went back to the house humming.

195 When the Kelveys were well out of sight of Burnells', they sat down to rest on a big red drain-pipe by the side of the road. Lil's cheeks were still burning; she took off the hat with the quill and held it on her knee. Dreamily they looked over the hay paddocks, past the creek, to the group of wattles where Logan's cows stood waiting to be milked. What were their thoughts? Presently our Else nudged up close to her sister. But now she had forgotten the cross lady. She put out a finger and stroked her sister's quill; she smiled her rare smile.

"I seen the little lamp," she said, softly. Then both were silent once more.

New Zealand Prime Minister Addresses United Nations General Assembly

Jacinda Ardern

2019

Ko ngā tangata katoa, e manaakitia ana te whenua, o te Ao Whānui (To all those who care for the lands of the wide world) Ko ngā kaitiaki, e riterite ana, ngā whenua, huri rauna, i te Ao (To the guardians of sustainability around the world) Me tū tatou ki te werohia I ngā wero (Stand and challenge the challenges) I te ingoa o te tika o ngā mea katoa (In the name of what is right with all things.) Tēnā koutou katoa (Greetings to you all)

Mr. President,

Mr. Secretary-General,

Friends,

I greet you in te reo Māori, language of the tangata whenua, or first people of Aotearoa New Zealand. I do so not just because it is the same way I would begin an address if I were at home, but because there are challenges we face as a world that I know no better way to express. Māori concepts like kaitiakitanga. The idea that each of us here today are guardians. Guardians of the land, of our environment and of our people. There is a simplicity to the notion of sovereign guardianship.

For decades we have assembled here under the assumption that we narrowly cooperate only on the issues that overtly impact on one another; issues like international trade rules, the law of the sea, or humanitarian access to war zones. The space in between has essentially been left to us. We, the political leaders of the world, have been the authors of our own domestic politics and policies. Decisions have been our own, and we have ultimately lived with the consequences.

But the world has changed.

Over time we have become increasingly interdependent. We see more and more often domestic decisions that have global ramifications.

Physical events have taught us that in obvious ways: oil spills that show no respect for maritime boundaries; nuclear accidents and testing, the impacts of which are never confined to the exact location in which they occur.

But our interdependence, our connection, runs so much deeper than that, and experiences in recent years should lead us all to question whether any of us ever truly operate in isolation anymore.

This is a question that we, the remote but connected nation of New Zealand, have been grappling with this year.

There are things that we are well known for in New Zealand. Green rolling hills, perfect you

might say for hobbits to hide and for plenty of sheep to roam. We're known for manaakitanga, or the pride we take in caring for our guests, so much so that it even extends to our most entrenched sporting rivals.

And now we are known for something else.

The 15th of March 2019.

The day an alleged terrorist undertook the most horrific attack on a place of worship, taking the lives of 51 innocent people, devastating our Muslim community and challenging our sense of who we are as a country.

Now there is no changing a nation's history, but we can choose how it defines us. And in Aotearoa New Zealand, the people who lined up outside of mosques with flowers, the young people who gathered spontaneously in parks and open spaces in a show of solidarity, the thousands who stopped in silence to acknowledge the call to prayer seven days later, and the Muslim community who showed only love – these are the people who collectively decided that New Zealand would not be defined by an act of brutality and violence, but instead by compassion and empathy.

Make no mistake though, we do not claim to be a perfect nation. While we are a home of more than 200 ethnicities, that does not mean we are free from racism and discrimination. We have wounds from our own history that, 250 years on from the first encounters between Māori and Europeans, we continue to address.

But since the terrorist attack in New Zealand, we have had to ask ourselves many hard and many difficult questions.

One example sticks in my mind. It was only days after the shooting and I visited a mosque in our capital city. After spending some time with community leaders, I exited and walked across the car park where members of the Muslim community were gathered. And out of the corner of my eye I saw a young boy gesture to me. He was shy, almost retreating towards a barrier, but he also had something he clearly wanted to say. I quickly crouched down next to him.

He didn't say his name or even hello, he simply whispered, "Will I be safe now?"

What does it take for a child to feel safe? As adults, we are quick to make the practical changes that will enable us to say that such a horrific act could never happen again. And we did that. Within 10 days of the attack we made a decision to change our gun laws and banned military style semi-automatic weapons and assault rifles in New Zealand. We have started on a second tranche of reforms to register weapons and to change our licensing regime.

These changes will help to make us safer. But when you're a child, fear is not discrete, and it cannot be removed through legislative acts or decrees from Parliament.

Feeling safe means the absence of fear. Living free from racism, bullying and discrimination. Feeling loved, included and able to be exactly who you are. And to feel truly safe, those conditions need to be universal. No matter who you are, no matter where you come from, no matter where you live.

The young Muslim boy in Kilbirnie, New Zealand, wanted to know if I could grant him all of those things.

My fear is, that as a leader of a proudly independent nation, this is one thing that I cannot achieve alone. Not anymore.

In our borderless and technologically connected world, commentary on race, acts of discrimination based on religion, gender, sexuality or ethnicity – they are not neatly confined behind boundaries. They are felt globally.

80 The fact I received so many letters from Muslim children from around the world in the weeks after March 15 speaks to the power of connection. These children had no sense of distance. They may have never heard of New Zealand before March 15. They just saw an act of hatred against their community, and it felt close to them.

85 Whether it is acts of violence, language intended to incite fear of religious groups or assumptions about ethnicities to breed distrust and racism – these actions and utterances are as globalised as the movement of goods and services.

Children hear them.

Women hear them.

People of faith hear them.

Our rainbow communities hear them.

90 And so now, it's our turn to stop and to listen. To accept that our words and actions have immeasurable consequences. And to speak not only like the whole world is listening, but with the responsibility of someone who knows a small child somewhere might be listening too.

95 The spaces in which we communicate, they are part of the challenge too, tough. In an increasingly online world we need to create spaces for the exchange of ideas, the sharing of technology and free speech, but also acknowledging the potential for this technology to be used to cause harm.

100 March 15 was a staggering example of such harm, and a deliberate effort to broadcast terror on a massive, viral scale over the internet. The alleged terrorist didn't just take the lives of 51 people, he did it live on Facebook.

In the first 24 hours after the attack, Facebook took down 1.5 million copies of the livestream video. YouTube saw a copy of the video uploaded, at times, as fast as once every second during the same period.

105 The alleged terrorist used social media as a weapon. The attack demonstrated how the internet, a global commons with extraordinary power to do good, can be perverted and used as a tool for terrorists.

110 And so what happened in Christchurch, as well as being a profound tragedy, is also a complex and ongoing problem for the world. And it's a problem we felt a sense of responsibility to do something about, so we sought to collaborate with the technology companies so integral to the solution.

Two months after the attacks, leaders gathered in Paris for the Christchurch Call, bringing together companies, countries and civil society, and committing to a range of actions to reduce the harm this content can cause. In doing so we have kept our focus on the deeper aim we all want: technology that unleashes human potential, not the worst in us.

115 Yesterday, I met with Call supporters to check in on our collective progress. We announced that a key tech industry institution will be reshaped to give effect to those commitments – and we launched a crisis response protocol to make sure that we can respond to such events in the future.

Neither New Zealand nor any other country could make these changes on their own. The
120 tech companies couldn't either. We are succeeding because we are working together, and for
that unprecedented and powerful act of unity New Zealand says thank you.

The centrality of technology in our lives is not the only example though of our increasing in-
terconnection and our reliance on one another if we are to respond to the challenges we face.
There is perhaps no better example of our absolute interdependence than climate change.

125 When the United Nations Secretary-General visited the Pacific region this year, he saw first-
hand how countries that have produced the fewest greenhouse gas emissions are now facing
the most catastrophic effects. In his words: "To save the Pacific is to save the whole planet."

In fact, seven out of the 15 most climate-affected nations in the world sit within the Pacific
region. Places like Tuvalu, with a population of just over 11,000 people, barely contributes to
130 global emissions but is paying the price for our collective inaction. Atolls so low lying that in
weather events the water on either side of it can flow together and join at the narrowest points.
Engulfed by the sea. Or Tokelau, a beautiful set of three atolls that can only be accessed by
boat, where the children speak knowledgeably about climate change, knowing that unlike all
of the challenges their self-reliant forbears have ever faced, this is the one that is completely
135 and utterly in other people's hands.

Now they have never met you, nor you them. But I can tell you that their expectations on all
of us are high.

Meeting those expectations will require us to use every policy lever available – and, just like
the Christchurch Call to Action, we need to work with partners inside and outside govern-
140 ment to make change.

[...]

We are being asked to make decisions that are local, but with consequences that are global.

And yet, this is what climate change requires us to do. That is what historically our commit-
ment to the United Nations Charter and the Universal Declaration of Human Rights asks
145 us to do. It's what standing up against acts of violence and discrimination asks us to do. Our
globalised, borderless world asks us to be guardians not just for our people, but for all people.

There may have been a time when being unified under common challenges was an easier
concept than it is today. But undeniably, we are living in a time where our greater reliance
on one another has collided with a period of greater tribalism.

150 It would be wrong to assume that this is a new phenomenon. Research, in fact, has shown
that humans are in fact so inclined to form natural tribes that if you put a completely uncon-
nected diverse group of people into a room and flip a coin for each, those two groups will
automatically form a suspicion of one another based on nothing more than heads vs tails.

Scientist and writer Robert Sapolsky recently reminded us that humans organise. Whether
155 it's class, race, country or coin flipping – there has always been a tendency to form us vs other.

But he also asks the question: what if we change what 'us' means? If instead of fierce nation-
alism or self-interest, we seek to form our tribes based on concepts that can and should be
universal.

What if we no longer see ourselves based on what we look like, what religion we practise, or
160 where we live. But by what we value. Humanity. Kindness. An innate sense of connection
to each other. And a belief that we are guardians, not just of our home and our planet, but of

each other.

We are borderless, but we are connected.

We are inherently different, but we have more that we share.

165 We may feel afraid, but as leaders we have the keys to create a sense of security, and a sense of hope.

We just need to choose.

Tātou tātou. No reira, tena koutou, tena kontou, tena koutou hatoa.

Chapter 2

The American South

The Kentucky Derby is Decadent and Depraved

Hunter S. Thompson

1970



I GOT OFF the plane around midnight and no one spoke as I crossed the dark runway to the terminal. The air was thick and hot, like wandering into a steam bath. Inside, people hugged each other and shook hands ... big grins and a whoop here and there: “By God! You old bastard! Good to see you, boy! Damn good ... and I mean it!”

In the air-conditioned lounge I met a man from Houston who said his name was something or other — “but just call me Jimbo” — and he was here to get it on. “I’m ready for anything, by God! Anything at all. Yeah, what are you drinkin?” I ordered a Margarita with ice, but he wouldn’t hear of it: “Naw, naw ... what the hell kind of drink is that for Kentucky Derby time? What’s wrong with you, boy?” He grinned and winked at the bartender. “Goddam, we gotta educate this boy. Get him some good whiskey ...”

I shrugged. “Okay, a double Old Fitz on ice.” Jimbo nodded his approval.

“Look.” He tapped me on the arm to make sure I was listening. “I know this Derby crowd, I come here every year, and let me tell you one thing I’ve learned — this is no town to be giving people the impression you’re some kind of faggot. Not in public, anyway. Shit, they’ll roll you in a minute, knock you in the head and take every goddam cent you have.”

I thanked him and fitted a Marlboro into my cigarette holder. “Say,” he said, “you look like you might be in the horse business ... am I right?”

“No,” I said. “I’m a photographer.”

“Oh yeah?” He eyed my ragged leather bag with new interest. “Is that what you got there — cameras? Who you work for?”

"Playboy," I said.

He laughed. "Well goddam! What are you gonna take pictures of — nekkid horses? Haw! I guess you'll be workin' pretty hard when they run the Kentucky Oaks. That's a race jut for fillies." He was laughing wildly. "Hell yes! And they'll all be nekkid too!"

I shook my head and said nothing; just stared at him for a moment, trying to look grim. "There's going to be trouble," I said. "My assignment is to take pictures of the riot."

"What riot?"

I hesitated, twirling the ice in my drink. "At the track. On Derby Day. The Black Panthers." I stared at him again. "Don't you read the newspapers?"

The grin on his face had collapsed. "What the hell are you talkin about?"

"Well ... maybe I shouldn't be telling you ..." I shrugged. "But hell, everybody seems to know. The cops and the National Guard have been getting ready for six weeks. They have 20,000 troops on alert at Fort Knox. They warned us — all the press and photographers — to wear helmets and special vests like flak jackets. We were told to expect shooting ..."

Director's Cut Looking back at classic works of sports journalism. "No!" he shouted; his hands flew up and hovered momentarily between us, as if to ward off the words he was hearing. Then he hacked his fist on the bar. "Those sons of bitches! God Almighty! The Kentucky Derby!" He kept shaking his head. "No! Jesus! That's almost too bad to believe!" Now he seemed to be jaggging on the stool, and when he looked up his eyes were misty. "Why? Why here? Don't they respect anything?"

I shrugged again. "It's not just the Panthers. The FBI says busloads of white crazies are coming in from all over the country — to mix with the crowd and attack all at once, from every direction. They'll be dressed like everybody else. You know — coats and ties and all that. But when the trouble starts ... well, that's why the cops are so worried."

He sat for a moment, looking hurt and confused and not quite able to digest all this terrible news. Then he cried out: "Oh ... Jesus! What in the name of God is happening in this country? Where can you get away from it?"

"Not here," I said, picking up my bag. "Thanks for the drink ... and good luck."

He grabbed my arm, urging me to have another, but I said I was overdue at the Press Club and hustled off to get my act together for the awful spectacle. At the airport newsstand I picked up a Courier-Journal and scanned the front page headlines: "Nixon Sends GI's into Cambodia to Hit Reds" ... "B-52's Raid, then 2,000 GI's Advance 20 Miles" ... "4,000 U.S. Troops Deployed Near Yale as Tension Grows Over Panther Protest." At the bottom of the page was a photo of Diane Crump, soon to become the first woman jockey ever to ride in the Kentucky Derby.³ The photographer had snapped her "stopping in the barn area to fondle her mount, Fathom." The rest of the paper was spotted with ugly war news and stories of "student unrest." There was no mention of any protest action at a small Ohio school called Kent State.⁴

I went to the Hertz desk to pick up my car, but the moon-faced young swinger in charge said they didn't have any. "You can't rent one anywhere," he assured me. "Our Derby reservations have been booked for six weeks." I explained that my agent had confirmed a white Chrysler convertible for me that very afternoon but he shook his head. "Maybe we'll have a cancellation. Where are you staying?"

65 I shrugged. "Where's the Texas crowd staying? I want to be with my people."
He sighed. "My friend, you're in trouble. This town is flat full. Always is, for the Derby."
I leaned closer to him, half-whispering: "Look, I'm from Playboy. How would you like a job?"

He backed off quickly. "What? Come on, now. What kind of a job?"
70 "Never mind," I said. "You just blew it." I swept my bag off the counter and went to find a cab. The bag is a valuable prop in this kind of work; mine has a lot of baggage tags on it — SF, LA, NY, Lima, Rome, Bangkok, that sort of thing — and the most prominent tag of all is a very official, plastic-coated thing that said "Photog. Playboy Mag." I bought it from a pimp in Vail, Colorado, and he told me how to use it. "Never mention Playboy until you're sure
75 they've seen this thing first," he said. "Then, when you see them notice it, that's the time to strike. They'll go belly up every time. This thing is magic, I tell you. Pure magic."

Well ... maybe so. I'd used it on the poor geek in the bar, and now, humming along in a Yellow Cab toward town, I felt a little guilty about jangling the poor bugger's brains with that evil fantasy. But, what the hell? Anybody who wanders around the world saying, "Yes,
80 I'm from Texas," deserves whatever happens to him. And he had, after all, come here once again to make a 19th century ass of himself in the midst of some jaded, atavistic freakout with nothing to recommend it except a very saleable "tradition." Early in our chat, Jimbo had told me that he hasn't missed a Derby since 1954. "The little lady won't come anymore," he said. "She just grits her teeth and turns me loose for this one. And when I say 'loose' I do mean
85 loose! I toss ten-dollar bills around like they were goin' outa style! Horses, whiskey, women ... shit, there's women in this town that'll do anything for money."

Why not? Money is a good thing to have in these twisted times. Even Richard Nixon is hungry for it. Only a few days before the Derby he said, "If I had any money I'd invest it in the stock market." And the market, meanwhile, continued its grim slide.

90 Waiting for Steadman

The next day was heavy. With 30 hours to post time I had no press credentials and — according to the sports editor of the Louisville Courier-Journal — no hope at all of getting any. Worse, I needed two sets; one for myself and another for Ralph Steadman, the English
95 illustrator who was coming from London to do some Derby drawings.⁵ All I knew about him was that this was his first visit to the United States. And the more I pondered that fact, the more it gave me fear. Would he bear up under the heinous culture shock of being lifted out of London and plunged into a drunken mob scene at the Kentucky Derby? There was no way of knowing. Hopefully, he would arrive at least a day or so ahead, and give himself time to get acclimated. Maybe a few hours of peaceful sightseeing in the Bluegrass country
100 around Lexington. My plan was to pick him up at the airport in the huge Pontiac Ballbuster I'd rented from a used car salesman named Colonel Quick, then whisk him off to some peaceful setting to remind him of England.

Colonel Quick had solved the car problem, and money (four times the normal rate) had bought two rooms in a scumbox on the outskirts of town. The only other kink was the task
105 of convincing the moguls at Churchill Downs that Scanlan's was such a prestigious sporting journal that common sense compelled them to give us two sets of the best press tickets. This was not easily done. My first call to the publicity office resulted in total failure. The press handler was shocked at the idea that anyone would be stupid enough to apply for press credentials two days before the Derby. "Hell, you can't be serious," he said. "The deadline was

110 two months ago. The press box is full; there's no more room ... and what the hell is Scanlan's Monthly anyway?"

I uttered a painful groan. "Didn't the London office call you? They're flying an artist over to do the paintings. Steadman. He's Irish, I think. Very famous over there. I just got in from the Coast. The San Francisco office told me we were all set."

115 He seemed interested, and even sympathetic, but there was nothing he could do. I flattered him with more gibberish, and finally he offered a compromise: he could get us two passes to the clubhouse grounds.

"That sounds a little weird," I said. "It's unacceptable. We must have access to everything. All of it. The spectacle, the people, the pageantry and certainly the race. You don't think we
120 came all this way to watch the damn thing on television, do you? One way or another we'll get inside. Maybe we'll have to bribe a guard — or even Mace somebody." (I had picked up a spray can of Mace in a downtown drugstore for \$5.98 and suddenly, in the midst of that phone talk, I was struck by the hideous possibilities of using it out at the track. Macing ushers at the narrow gates to the clubhouse inner sanctum, then slipping quickly inside, firing a
125 huge load of Mace into the governor's box, just as the race starts. Or Macing helpless drunks in the clubhouse restroom, for their own good ...)

By noon on Friday I was still without credentials and still unable to locate Steadman. For all I knew he'd changed his mind and gone back to London. Finally, after giving up on Steadman and trying unsuccessfully to reach my man in the press office, I decided my only hope for
130 credentials was to go out to the track and confront the man in person, with no warning — demanding only one pass now, instead of two, and talking very fast with a strange lilt in my voice, like a man trying hard to control some inner frenzy. On the way out, I stopped at the motel desk to cash a check. Then, as a useless afterthought, I asked if by any wild chance Mr. Steadman had checked in.

135 The lady on the desk was about fifty years old and very peculiar-looking; when I mentioned Steadman's name she nodded, without looking up from whatever she was writing, and said in a low voice, "You bet he did." Then she favored me with a big smile. "Yes, indeed. Mr. Steadman just left for the racetrack. Is he a friend of yours?"

I shook my head. "I'm supposed to be working with him, but I don't even know what he
140 looks like. Now, goddammit, I'll have to find him in that mob at the track."

She chuckled. "You won't have any trouble finding him. You could pick that man out of any crowd."

"Why?" I asked. "What's wrong with him? What does he look like?"

"Well ... " she said, still grinning, "he's the funniest looking thing I've seen in a long time. He
145 has this ... ah ... this growth all over his face. As a matter of fact it's all over his head." She nodded. "You'll know him when you see him; don't worry about that."

Great creeping Jesus, I thought. That screws the press credentials. I had a vision of some nerve-rattling geek all covered with matted hair and string-warts showing up in the press of-
fice and demanding Scanlan's press packet. Well ... what the hell? We could always load up
150 on acid and spend the day roaming around the grounds with big sketch pads, laughing hysterically at the natives and swilling mint juleps so the cops wouldn't think we're abnormal. Perhaps even make the act pay up: set up an easel with a big sign saying, "Let a Foreign Artist Paint Your Portrait, \$10 Each. Do It NOW!"

A Huge Outdoor Loony Bin I took the expressway out to the track, driving very fast and
155 jumping the monster car back and forth between lanes, driving with a beer in one hand and
my mind so muddled that I almost crushed a Volkswagen full of nuns when I swerved to
catch the right exit. There was a slim chance, I thought, that I might be able to catch the ugly
Britisher before he checked in.

But Steadman was already in the press box when I got there, a bearded young Englishman
160 wearing a tweed coat and HAF sunglasses.⁶ There was nothing particularly odd about him.
No facial veins or clumps of bristly warts. I told him about the motel woman's description
and he seemed puzzled. "Don't let it bother you," I said. "Just keep in mind for the next
few days that we're in Louisville, Kentucky. Not London. Not even New York. This is a
weird place. You're lucky that mental defective at the motel didn't jerk a pistol out of the
165 cash register and blow a big hole in you." I laughed, but he looked worried.⁷

"Just pretend you're visiting a huge outdoor loony bin," I said. "If the inmates get out of control
we'll soak them down with Mace." I showed him the can of "Chemical Billy," resisting
the urge to fire it across the room at a rat-faced man typing diligently in the Associated Press
section. We were standing at the bar, sipping the management's scotch and congratulating
170 each other on our sudden, unexplained luck in picking up two sets of fine press credentials.
The lady at the desk had been very friendly to him, he said. "I just told her my name and she
gave me the whole works."

By midafternoon we had everything under control. We had seats looking down on the finish
line, color TV and a free bar in the press room, and a selection of passes that would take
175 us anywhere from the clubhouse roof to the jockey room. The only thing we lacked was
unlimited access to the clubhouse inner sanctum in sections "F&G" ... and I felt we needed
that, to see the whisky gentry in action. The governor would be in "G." Barry Goldwater
would be in a box in "G" where we could rest and sip juleps, soak up a bit of atmosphere and
the Derby's special vibrations.

180 The bars and dining rooms were also in "F&G," and the clubhouse bars on Derby Day are a
very special kind of scene. Along with the politicians, society belle and local captains of commerce,
every half-mad dingbat who ever had any pretensions to anything within 500 miles of
Louisville will show up there to get strutting drunk and slap a lot of backs and generally make
himself obvious. The Paddock bar is probably the best place in the track to sit and watch
185 faces. Nobody minds being stared at; that's what they're in there for. Some people spend
most of their time in the Paddock; they can hunker down at one of the many wooden tables,
lean back in a comfortable chair and watch the ever-changing odds flash up and down on
the big tote board outside the window. Black waiters in white serving jackets move through
the crowd with trays of drinks, while the experts ponder their racing forms and the hunch
190 bettors pick lucky numbers or scan the lineup for right-sounding names. There is a constant
flow of traffic to and from the pari-mutuel windows outside in the wooden corridors. Then,
as post time nears, the crowd thins out as people go back to their boxes.

Clearly, we were going to have to figure out some way to spend more time in the clubhouse
tomorrow. But the "walkaround" press passes to F&G were only good for 30 minutes at a
195 time, presumably to allow the newspaper types to rush in and out for photos or quick interviews,
but to prevent drifters like Steadman and me from spending all day in the clubhouse,
harassing the gentry and rifling an old handbag or two while cruising around the boxes. Or
macing the governor. The time limit was no problem on Friday, but on Derby Day the walkaround
passes would be in heavy demand. And since it took about 10 minutes to get from
200 the press box to the Paddock, and 10 more minutes to get back, that didn't leave much time

for serious people-watching. And unlike most of the others in the press box, we didn't give a hoot in hell what was happening on the track. We had come there to watch the real beasts perform.

205 View from Thompson's Head Later Friday afternoon, we went out on the balcony of the press box and I tried to describe the difference between what we had seen today and what would be happening tomorrow. This was the first time I'd been to a Derby in 10 years, but before that, when I lived in Louisville, I used to go every year. Now, looking down from the press box, I pointed to the huge grassy meadow enclosed by the track. "That whole thing," I said, "will be jammed with people; fifty thousand or so, and most of them staggering drunk.
210 It's a fantastic scene — thousands of people fainting, crying, copulating, trampling each other and fighting with broken whiskey bottles. We'll have to spend some time out there, but it's hard to move around, too many bodies."

"Is it safe out there? Will we ever come back?"

"Sure," I said. "We'll just have to be careful not to step on anybody's stomach and start
215 a fight." I shrugged. "Hell, this clubhouse scene right below us will be almost as bad as the infield. Thousands of raving, stumbling drunks, getting angrier and angrier as they lose more and more money. By midafternoon they'll be guzzling mint juleps with both hands and vomiting on each other between races. The whole place will be jammed with bodies, shoulder to shoulder. It's hard to move around. The aisles will be slick with vomit; people falling down
220 and grabbing at your legs to keep from being stomped. Drunks pissing on themselves in the betting lines. Dropping handfuls of money and fighting to stoop over and pick it up."

He looked so nervous that I laughed. "I'm just kidding," I said. "Don't worry. At the first hint of trouble I'll start Macing everybody I can reach."

He had done a few good sketches but so far we hadn't seen that special kind of face that I felt
225 we would need for the lead drawing. It was a face I'd seen a thousand times at every Derby I'd ever been to. I saw it, in my head, as the mask of the whiskey gentry — a pretentious mix of booze, failed dreams and a terminal identity crisis; the inevitable result of too much inbreeding in a closed and ignorant culture. One of the key genetic rules in breeding dogs, horses or any other kind of thoroughbred is that close inbreeding tends to magnify the weak
230 points in a bloodline as well as the strong points. In horse breeding, for instance, there is a definite risk in breeding two fast horses who are both a little crazy. The offspring will likely be very fast and also very crazy. So the trick in breeding thoroughbreds is to retain the good traits and filter out the bad. But the breeding of humans is not so wisely supervised, particularly in a narrow Southern society where the closest kind of inbreeding is not only stylish and
235 acceptable, but far more convenient — to the parents — than setting their offspring free to find their own mates, for their own reasons and their own ways. ("Goddam, did you hear about Smitty's daughter? She went crazy in Boston last week and married a nigger!")

So the face I was trying to find in Churchill Downs that weekend was a symbol, in my own mind, of the whole doomed atavistic culture that makes the Kentucky Derby what it is.

240 On our way back to the motel after Friday's races I warned Steadman about some of the other problems we'd have to cope with. Neither of us had brought any strange illegal drugs, so we would have to get by on booze. "You should keep in mind," I said, "that almost everybody you talk to from now on will be drunk. People who seem very pleasant at first might suddenly swing at you for no reason at all." He nodded, staring straight ahead. He seemed to be
245 getting a little numb and I tried to cheer him up by inviting him to dinner that night, with my brother.

“What Mace?”

Back at the motel we talked for a while about America, the South, England, just relaxing a bit before dinner. There was no way either of us could have known, at the time, that it would be the last normal conversation we would have. From that point on, the weekend became a vicious, drunken nightmare. We both went completely to pieces. The main problem was my prior attachment to Louisville, which naturally led to meetings with old friends, relatives, etc., many of whom were in the process of falling apart, going mad, plotting divorces, cracking up under the strain of terrible debts or recovering from bad accidents. Right in the middle of the whole frenzied Derby action, a member of my own family had to be institutionalized.⁸ This added a certain amount of strain to the situation, and since poor Steadman had no choice but to take whatever came his way, he was subjected to shock after shock.

Another problem was his habit of sketching people he met in the various social situations I dragged him into, then giving them the sketches. The results were always unfortunate. I warned him several times about letting the subjects see his foul renderings, but for some perverse reason he kept doing it. Consequently, he was regarded with fear and loathing⁹ by nearly everyone who'd seen or even heard about his work. He couldn't understand it. “It's sort of a joke,” he kept saying. “Why, in England it's quite normal. People don't take offense. They understand that I'm just putting them on a bit.”

“Fuck England,” I said. “This is Middle America. These people regard what you're doing to them as a brutal, bilious insult. Look what happened last night. I thought my brother was going to tear your head off.”

Steadman shook his head sadly, “But I like him. He struck me as a very decent, straightforward sort.”

“Look, Ralph,” I said. “Let's not kid ourselves. That was a very horrible drawing you gave him. It was the face of a monster. It got on his nerves very badly.” I shrugged. “Why in the hell do you think we left the restaurant so fast?”

“I thought it was because of the Mace,” he said.

“What Mace?”

He grinned. “When you shot it at the headwaiter, don't you remember?”¹⁰

“Hell, that was nothing,” I said. “I missed him ... and we were leaving, anyway.”

“But it got all over us,” he said. “The room was full of that damn gas. Your brother was sneezing and his wife was crying. My eyes hurt for two hours. I couldn't see to draw when we got back to the motel.”

“That's right,” I said. “The stuff got on her leg, didn't it?”

“She was angry,” he said.

“Yah ... well, okay ... let's just figure we fucked up about equally on that one,” I said. “But from now on let's try to be careful when we're around people I know. You won't sketch them and I won't Mace them. We'll just try to relax and get drunk.”

“Right,” he said. “We'll go native.”

Derby Morning

It was Saturday morning, the day of the Big Race, and we were having breakfast in a plastic hamburger palace called the Ptomaine Village. Our rooms were just across the road in a

290 foul scumbox of a place called the Horn Suburban Hotel. They had a dining room, but the food was so bad that we couldn't handle it anymore. The waitresses seemed to be suffering from shin splints; they moved around very slowly, moaning and cursing the "darkies" in the kitchen.

295 Steadman liked the Ptomaine Village because it had fish and chips. I preferred the "french toast," which was really pancake batter, fried to the proper thickness and then chopped out with a sort of cookie cutter to resemble pieces of toast.

300 Beyond drink and lack of sleep, our only real problem at that point was the question of access to the clubhouse. Finally we decided just to go ahead and steal two passes, if necessary, rather than miss that part of the action. This was the last coherent decision we were able to make for the next 48 hours. From that point on — almost from the very moment we started out to the track — we lost all control of events and spent the rest of the weekend just churning around in a sea of drunken horrors. My notes and recollections from Derby Day are somewhat scrambled.

305 But now, looking at the big red notebook I carried all through that scene, I see more or less that happened. The book itself is somewhat mangled and bent; some of the pages are torn, others are shriveled and stained by what appears to be whiskey, but taken as a whole, with sporadic memory flashes, the notes seem to tell the story. To wit:

Unscrambling Derby Day — I Steadman Is Worried About Fire

310 Rain all nite until dawn. No sleep. Christ, here we go, a nightmare of mud and madness Drunks in the mud. Drowning, fighting for shelter But no. By noon the sun burns, perfect day, not even humid.

315 Steadman is now worried about Fire. Somebody told him about the clubhouse catching on fire two years ago. Could it happen again? Horrible. Trapped in the press box. Holocaust. A hundred thousand people fighting to get out. Drunks screaming in the flames and the mud, crazed horses running wild. Blind in the smoke. Grandstand collapsing into the flames with us on the roof. Poor Ralph is about to crack. Drinking heavily, into the Haig.

Out to the track in a cab, avoid that terrible parking in people's front yards, \$25 each, toothless old men on the street with big signs: Park Here, flagging cars in the yard. "That's fine, boy, never mind the tulips." Wild hair on his head, straight up like a clump of reeds.

320 Sidewalks full of people all moving in the same direction, towards Churchill Downs. Kids hauling coolers and blankets, teenyboppers in tight pink shorts, many blacks ... black dudes in white felt hats with leopard-skin bands, cops waving traffic along.

325 The mob was thick for many blocks around the track; very slow going in the crowd, very hot. On the way to the press box elevator, just inside the clubhouse, we came on a row of soldiers all carrying long white riot sticks. About two platoons, with helmets. A man walking next to us said they were waiting for the governor and his party. Steadman eyed them nervously. "Why do they have those clubs?"

330 "Black Panthers," I said. Then I remembered good old "Jimbo" at the airport and I wondered what he was thinking right now. Probably very nervous; the place was teeming with cops and soldiers. We pressed on through the crowd, through many gates, past the paddock where the jockeys bring the horses out and parade around for a while before each race so the bettors can get a good look. Five million dollars will be bet today. Many winners, more losers. What the hell. The press gate was jammed up with people trying to get in, shouting at the guards, waving strange press badges: Chicago Sporting Times, Pittsburgh Police Athletic League ...

they were all turned away. "Move on, fella, make way for the working press." We shoved
335 through the crowd and into the elevator, then quickly up to the free bar. Why not? Get it
on. Very hot today, not feeling well, must be this rotten climate. The press box was cool and
airy, plenty of room to walk around and balcony seats for watching the race or looking down
at the crowd. We got a betting sheet and went outside.

Unscrambling D-day II Clubhouse/Paddock Bar

340 Pink faces with stylish Southern sag, old Ivy styles, seersucker coats and buttondown collars.
"Mayblossom Senility" (Steadman's phrase) ... burnt out early or maybe just not much to
burn in the first place. Not much energy in these faces, not much curiosity. Suffering in
silence, nowhere to go after thirty in this life, just hang on and humor the children. Let
the young enjoy themselves while they can. Why not? The grim reaper comes early in this
345 league ... banshees on the lawn at night, screaming out there beside that little iron nigger in
jockey clothes. Maybe he's the one who's screaming. Bad DT's and too many snarls at the
bridge club. Going down with the stock market. Oh Jesus, the kid has wrecked the new car,
wrapped it around that big stone pillar at the bottom of the driveway. Broken leg? Twisted
eye? Send him off to Yale, they can cure anything up there.

350 Yale? Did you see today's paper? New Haven is under siege. Yale is swarming with Black
PanthersI tell you, Colonel, the world has gone mad, stone mad. Why they tell me a
goddam woman jockey might ride in the Derby today.

I left Steadman sketching in the Paddock bar and sent off to place our bets on the sixth race.
When I came back he was staring intently at a group of young men around a stable not far
355 away. "Jesus, look at the corruption in that face!" he whispered. "Look at the madness, the
fear, the greed!" I looked, then quickly turned my back on the table he was drawing. The
face he'd picked out to draw was the face of an old friend of mine, a prep school football star
in the good old days with a sleek red Chevy convertible and a very quick hand, it was said,
with the snaps of a 32 B brassiere. They called him "Cat Man."

360 But now, a dozen years later, I wouldn't have recognized him anywhere but here, where I
should have expected to find him, in the Paddock bar on Derby Day ... fat slanted eyes and a
pimp's smoke, blue silk suit and his friends looking like crooked bank tellers on a binge

Steadman wanted to see some Kentucky Colonels, but he wasn't sure what they looked like.
I told him to go back to the clubhouse men's rooms and look for men in white linen suits
365 vomiting in the urinals. "They'll usually have large brown whiskey stains on the fronts of
their suits," I said. "But watch the shoes, that's the tip-off. Most of them manage to avoid
vomiting on their own clothes, but they never miss their shoes."

In a box not far from ours was Colonel Anna Friedman Goldman, Chairman and Keeper of
the Great Seal of the Honorable Order of Kentucky Colonels. Not all the 76 million or so
370 Kentucky Colonels could make it to the Derby this year, but many had kept the faith and
several days prior to the Derby they gathered for their annual dinner at the Seelbach Hotel.

The Derby, the actual race, was scheduled for late afternoon, and as the magic hour ap-
proached I suggested to Steadman that we should probably spend some time in the infield,
that boiling sea of people across the track from the clubhouse. He seemed a little nervous
375 about it, but since none of the awful things I'd warned him about had happened so far — no
race riots, firestorms, or savage drunken attacks — he shrugged and said, "Right, let's do it."

To get there we had to pass through many gates, each one a step down in status, then through
a tunnel under the track. Emerging from the tunnel was such a culture shock that it took us

a while to adjust. "Cool almighty!" Steadman muttered. "This is a ... Jesus!" He plunged
380 ahead with his tiny camera, stepping over bodies, and I followed, trying to take notes.

Unscrambling D-day III The Infield

Total chaos, no way to see the race, not even the track... nobody cares. Big lines at the outdoor
betting windows, then stand back to watch winning numbers flash on the big board, like a
giant bingo game.

385 Old blacks arguing about bets; "hold on there, I'll handle this" (waving pint of whiskey, fist-
ful of dollar bills); girl riding piggyback, T-shirt says, "Stolen from Fort Lauderdale Jail."
Thousands of teenagers, group singing "Let the Sun Shine In," ten soldiers guarding the
American flag, and a huge fat drunk wearing a blue football jersey (No. 80) reeling around
with quart of beer in hand.

390 No booze sold out here, too dangerous ... no bathrooms either. Muscle Beach ... Woodstock
... many cops with riot sticks, but no sign of riot. Far across the track the clubhouse looks
like a postcard from the Kentucky Derby.

Unscrambling D-day IV "My Old Kentucky Home"

We went back to the clubhouse to watch the big race. When the crowd stood to face the flag
395 and sing "My Old Kentucky Home," Steadman faced the crowd and sketched frantically.
Somewhere up in the boxes a voice screeched, "Turn around, you hairy freak!" The race
itself was only two minutes long, and even from our super-status seats and using 12-power
glasses, there was no way to see what was really happening. Later, watching a TV rerun in the
press box, we saw what happened to our horses. Holy Land, Ralph's choice, stumbled and
400 lost his jockey in the final turn. Mine, Silent Screen, had the lead coming into the stretch,
but faded to fifth at the finish. The winner was a 16-1 shot named Dust Commander.

Moments after the race was over, the crowd surged wildly for the exits, rushing for cabs and
busses. The next day's Courier told of violence in the parking lot; people were punched and
trampled, pockets were picked, children lost, bottles hurled. But we missed all this, having
405 retired to the press box for a bit of post-race drinking. By this time we were both half-crazy
from too much whiskey, sun fatigue, culture shock, lack of sleep and general dissolution.
We hung around the press box long enough to watch a mass interview with the winning
owner, a dapper little man named Lehmann who said he had just flown into Louisville that
morning from Nepal, where he'd "bagged a record tiger." 11 The sportswriters murmured
410 their admiration and a waiter filled Lehmann's glass with Chivas Regal. He had just won
127,000*with a horse that cost him* 6,500 two years ago. His occupation, he said, was "re-
tired contractor." And then he added, with a big grin, "I just retired."

The rest of that day blurs into madness. The rest of that night too. And all the next day
and night. Such horrible things occurred that I can't bring myself even to think about them
415 now, much less put them down in print. Steadman was lucky to get out of Louisville without
serious injuries, and I was lucky to get out at all. One of my clearest memories of that vicious
time is Ralph being attacked by one of my old friends in the billiard room of the Pendennis
Club 12 in downtown Louisville on Saturday night. The man had ripped his own shirt open
to the waist before deciding that Ralph wasn't after his wife. No blows were struck, but the
420 emotional effects were massive. Then, as a sort of final horror, Steadman put his fiendish pen
to work and tried to patch things up by doing a little sketch of the girl he'd been accused of
hustling. That finished us in the Pendennis.

Getting Out of Town

Sometime around 10:30 Monday morning I was awakened by a scratching sound at my door.
425 I leaned out of bed and pulled the curtain back just far enough to see Steadman outside.
“What the fuck do you want?” I shouted.

“What about having breakfast?” he said.

I lunged out of bed and tried to open the door, but it caught on the night-chain and banged
shut again. I couldn’t cope with the chain! The thing wouldn’t come out of the track — so
430 I ripped it out of the wall with a vicious jerk on the door. Ralph didn’t blink. “Bad luck,” he
muttered.

I could barely see him. My eyes were swollen almost shut and the sudden burst of sunlight
through the door left me stunned and helpless like a sick mole. Steadman was mumbling
about sickness and terrible heat; I fell back on the bed and tried to focus on him as he moved
435 around the room in a very distracted way for a few moments, then suddenly darted over to
the beer bucket and seized a Colt .45. “Christ,” I said. “you’re getting out of control.”

He nodded and ripped the cap off, taking a long drink. “You know, this is really awful,” he
said finally. “I must get out of this place ...” he shook his head nervously. “The plane leaves
at 3:30, but I don’t know if I’ll make it.”

440 I barely heard him. My eyes had finally opened enough for me to focus on the mirror across
the room and I was stunned at the shock of recognition. For a confused instant I thought
that Ralph had brought somebody with him — a model for that one special face we’d been
looking for. There he was, by God — a puffy, drink-ravaged, disease-ridden caricature ...
like an awful cartoon version of an old snapshot in some once-proud mother’s family photo
445 album. It was the face we’d been looking for — and it was, of course, my own. Horrible,
horrible ...

“Maybe I should sleep a while longer,” I said. “Why don’t you go on over to the Ptomaine
Village and eat some of those rotten fish and chips? Then come back and get me around
noon. I feel too near death to hit the streets at this hour.”

450 He shook his head. “No ... no ... I think I’ll go back upstairs and work on those drawings for
a while.” He leaned down to fetch two more cans out of the beer bucket. “I tried to work
earlier,” he said, “but my hands keep trembling ... It’s teddible, teddible.”

“You’ve got to stop drinking,” I said.

He nodded. “I know. This is no good, no good at all. But for some reason I think it makes
455 me feel better ...”

“Not for long,” I said. “You’ll probably collapse into some kind of hysterical DT’s tonight
— probably just about the time you get off the plane at Kennedy. They’ll zip you up in a
straightjacket and drag you down to the Tombs, then beat you on the kidneys with a big
stick until you straighten out.”

460 He shrugged and wandered out, pulling the door shut behind him. I went back to bed for
another hour or so, and later — after the daily grapefruit juice run to the Nite Owl Food
Mart — we drove once again to the Ptomaine Village for a fine lunch of dough and butcher’s
offal, fried in heavy grease.

By this time Ralph wouldn’t even order coffee; he kept asking for more water. “It’s the only
465 thing they have that’s fit for human consumption,” he explained. Then, with an hour or so
to kill before he had to catch the plane, we spread his drawings out on the table and pondered
them for a while, wondering if he’d caught the proper spirit of the thing ... but we couldn’t

make up our minds. His hands were shaking so badly that he had trouble holding the paper, and my vision was so blurred that I could barely see what he's drawn. "Shit," I said. "We
470 both look worse than anything you've drawn here."

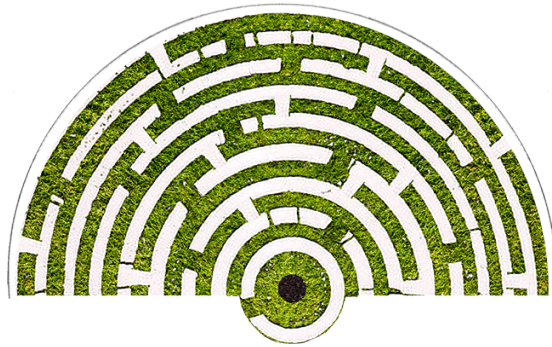
He smiled. "You know — I've been thinking about that," he said. "We came down here to see this teddible scene: people all pissed out of their minds and vomiting on themselves and all that ... and now, you know what? It's us ..."

Huge Pontiac Ballbuster blowing through traffic on the expressway. The journalist is driving,
475 ignoring his passenger who is now nearly naked after taking off most of his clothing, which he holds out the window, trying to wind-wash the Mace out of it. His eyes are bright red and his face and chest are soaked with the beer he's been using to rinse the awful chemical off his flesh. The front of his woolen trousers is soaked with vomit; his body is racked with fits of coughing and wild choking sobs. The journalist rams the big car through traffic and
480 into a spot in front of the terminal, then he reaches over to open the door on the passenger's side and shoves the Englishman out, snarling: "Bug off, you worthless faggot! You twisted pigfucker! [Crazed laughter.] If I weren't sick I'd kick your ass all the way to Bowling Green — you scumsucking foreign geek. Mace is too good for you We can do without your kind in Kentucky."

S-Town

Brian Reed

2017



<https://stownpodcast.org/chapter/1>

A Rose for Emily

William Faulkner

1922

WHEN Miss Emily Grierson died, our whole town went to her funeral: the men through a sort of respectful affection for a fallen monument, the women mostly out of curiosity to see the inside of her house, which no one save an old man-servant—a combined gardener and cook—had seen in at least ten years.

subs. hengivelse

5 It was a big, squarish frame house that had once been white, decorated with cupolas and spires and scrolled balconies in the heavily lightsome style of the seventies, set on what had once been our most select street. But garages and cotton gins had encroached and obliterated even the august names of that neighborhood; only Miss Emily's house was left, lifting its stubborn and coquettish decay above the cotton wagons and the gasoline pumps—an eyesore
10 among eyesores. And now Miss Emily had gone to join the representatives of those august names where they lay in the cedar-bemused cemetery among the ranked and anonymous graves of Union and Confederate soldiers who fell at the battle of Jefferson.

Alive, Miss Emily had been a tradition, a duty, and a care; a sort of hereditary obligation upon the town, dating from that day in 1894 when Colonel Sartoris, the mayor—he who fathered
15 the edict that no Negro woman should appear on the streets without an apron—remitted her taxes, the dispensation dating from the death of her father on into perpetuity. Not that Miss Emily would have accepted charity. Colonel Sartoris invented an involved tale to the effect that Miss Emily's father had loaned money to the town, which the town, as a matter of business, preferred this way of repaying. Only a man of Colonel Sartoris' generation and thought
20 could have invented it, and only a woman could have believed it.

When the next generation, with its more modern ideas, became mayors and aldermen, this arrangement created some little dissatisfaction. On the first of the year they mailed her a tax notice. February came, and there was no reply. They wrote her a formal letter, asking her to call at the sheriff's office at her convenience. A week later the mayor wrote her himself,
25 offering to call or to send his car for her, and received in reply a note on paper of an archaic shape, in a thin, flowing calligraphy in faded ink, to the effect that she no longer went out at all. The tax notice was also enclosed, without comment.

They called a special meeting of the Board of Aldermen. A deputation waited upon her, knocked at the door through which no visitor had passed since she ceased giving china-painting lessons eight or ten years earlier. They were admitted by the old Negro into a dim
30 hall from which a stairway mounted into still more shadow. It smelled of dust and disuse—a close, dank smell. The Negro led them into the parlor. It was furnished in heavy, leather-covered furniture. When the Negro opened the blinds of one window, they could see that the leather was cracked; and when they sat down, a faint dust rose sluggishly about their
35 thighs, spinning with slow motes in the single sun-ray. On a tarnished gilt easel before the fireplace stood a crayon portrait of Miss Emily's father.

They rose when she entered—a small, fat woman in black, with a thin gold chain descending to her waist and vanishing into her belt, leaning on an ebony cane with a tarnished gold

head. Her skeleton was small and spare; perhaps that was why what would have been merely
40 plumpness in another was obesity in her. She looked bloated, like a body long submerged in
motionless water, and of that pallid hue. Her eyes, lost in the fatty ridges of her face, looked
like two small pieces of coal pressed into a lump of dough as they moved from one face to
another while the visitors stated their errand.

She did not ask them to sit. She just stood in the door and listened quietly until the spokesman
45 came to a stumbling halt. Then they could hear the invisible watch ticking at the end of the
gold chain.

Her voice was dry and cold. "I have no taxes in Jefferson. Colonel Sartoris explained it to me.
Perhaps one of you can gain access to the city records and satisfy yourselves."

"But we have. We are the city authorities, Miss Emily. Didn't you get a notice from the
50 sheriff, signed by him?"

"I received a paper, yes," Miss Emily said. "Perhaps he considers himself the sheriff. . . I have
no taxes in Jefferson."

"But there is nothing on the books to show that, you see We must go by the—"

"See Colonel Sartoris. I have no taxes in Jefferson."

55 "But, Miss Emily—"

"See Colonel Sartoris." (Colonel Sartoris had been dead almost ten years.) "I have no taxes
in Jefferson. Tobe!" The Negro appeared. "Show these gentlemen out."

II

So SHE vanquished them, horse and foot, just as she had vanquished their fathers thirty years
60 before about the smell.

That was two years after her father's death and a short time after her sweetheart—the one
we believed would marry her —had deserted her. After her father's death she went out very
little; after her sweetheart went away, people hardly saw her at all. A few of the ladies had the
temerity to call, but were not received, and the only sign of life about the place was the Negro
65 man—a young man then—going in and out with a market basket.

"Just as if a man—any man—could keep a kitchen properly," the ladies said; so they were not
surprised when the smell developed. It was another link between the gross, teeming world
and the high and mighty Griersons.

A neighbor, a woman, complained to the mayor, Judge Stevens, eighty years old.

70 "But what will you have me do about it, madam?" he said.

"Why, send her word to stop it," the woman said. "Isn't there a law? "

"I'm sure that won't be necessary," Judge Stevens said. "It's probably just a snake or a rat that
n— of hers killed in the yard. I'll speak to him about it."

The next day he received two more complaints, one from a man who came in diffident dep-
75 recation. "We really must do something about it, Judge. I'd be the last one in the world
to bother Miss Emily, but we've got to do something." That night the Board of Aldermen
met—three graybeards and one younger man, a member of the rising generation.

"It's simple enough," he said. "Send her word to have her place cleaned up. Give her a certain
time to do it in, and if she don't. . ."

80 "Dammit, sir," Judge Stevens said, "will you accuse a lady to her face of smelling bad?"

So the next night, after midnight, four men crossed Miss Emily's lawn and slunk about the house like burglars, sniffing along the base of the brickwork and at the cellar openings while one of them performed a regular sowing motion with his hand out of a sack slung from his shoulder. They broke open the cellar door and sprinkled lime there, and in all the outbuild-
85 ings. As they recrossed the lawn, a window that had been dark was lighted and Miss Emily sat in it, the light behind her, and her upright torso motionless as that of an idol. They crept quietly across the lawn and into the shadow of the locusts that lined the street. After a week or two the smell went away.

That was when people had begun to feel really sorry for her. People in our town, remembering how old lady Wyatt, her great-aunt, had gone completely crazy at last, believed that the Griersons held themselves a little too high for what they really were. None of the young men were quite good enough for Miss Emily and such. We had long thought of them as a tableau, Miss Emily a slender figure in white in the background, her father a spraddled silhouette in the foreground, his back to her and clutching a horsewhip, the two of them framed by the
95 back-flung front door. So when she got to be thirty and was still single, we were not pleased exactly, but vindicated; even with insanity in the family she wouldn't have turned down all of her chances if they had really materialized.

When her father died, it got about that the house was all that was left to her; and in a way, people were glad. At last they could pity Miss Emily. Being left alone, and a pauper, she had
100 become humanized. Now she too would know the old thrill and the old despair of a penny more or less.

The day after his death all the ladies prepared to call at the house and offer condolence and aid, as is our custom Miss Emily met them at the door, dressed as usual and with no trace of grief on her face. She told them that her father was not dead. She did that for three days,
105 with the ministers calling on her, and the doctors, trying to persuade her to let them dispose of the body. Just as they were about to resort to law and force, she broke down, and they buried her father quickly.

We did not say she was crazy then. We believed she had to do that. We remembered all the young men her father had driven away, and we knew that with nothing left, she would have
110 to cling to that which had robbed her, as people will.

III

SHE WAS SICK for a long time. When we saw her again, her hair was cut short, making her look like a girl, with a vague resemblance to those angels in colored church windows—sort of tragic and serene.

115 The town had just let the contracts for paving the sidewalks, and in the summer after her father's death they began the work. The construction company came with n—s and mules and machinery, and a foreman named Homer Barron, a Yankee—a big, dark, ready man, with a big voice and eyes lighter than his face. The little boys would follow in groups to hear him cuss the n—s, and the n—s singing in time to the rise and fall of picks. Pretty soon he
120 knew everybody in town. Whenever you heard a lot of laughing anywhere about the square, Homer Barron would be in the center of the group. Presently we began to see him and Miss Emily on Sunday afternoons driving in the yellow-wheeled buggy and the matched team of bays from the livery stable.

At first we were glad that Miss Emily would have an interest, because the ladies all said, "Of

125 course a Grierson would not think seriously of a Northerner, a day laborer." But there were still others, older people, who said that even grief could not cause a real lady to forget noblesse oblige – without calling it noblesse oblige. They just said, "Poor Emily. Her kinsfolk should come to her." She had some kin in Alabama; but years ago her father had fallen out with them over the estate of old lady Wyatt, the crazy woman, and there was no communication
130 between the two families. They had not even been represented at the funeral. And as soon as the old people said, "Poor Emily," the whispering began. "Do you suppose it's really so?" they said to one another. "Of course it is. What else could . . ." This behind their hands; rustling of craned silk and satin behind jalousies closed upon the sun of Sunday afternoon as the thin, swift clop-clop-clop of the matched team passed: "Poor Emily."

135 She carried her head high enough—even when we believed that she was fallen. It was as if she demanded more than ever the recognition of her dignity as the last Grierson; as if it had wanted that touch of earthiness to reaffirm her imperviousness. Like when she bought the rat poison, the arsenic. That was over a year after they had begun to say "Poor Emily," and while the two female cousins were visiting her.

140 "I want some poison," she said to the druggist. She was over thirty then, still a slight woman, though thinner than usual, with cold, haughty black eyes in a face the flesh of which was strained across the temples and about the eyesockets as you imagine a lighthouse-keeper's face ought to look. "I want some poison," she said.

"Yes, Miss Emily. What kind? For rats and such? I'd recom—"

145 "I want the best you have. I don't care what kind."

The druggist named several. "They'll kill anything up to an elephant. But what you want is—"

"Arsenic," Miss Emily said. "Is that a good one?"

"Is . . . arsenic? Yes, ma'am. But what you want—"

150 "I want arsenic."

The druggist looked down at her. She looked back at him, erect, her face like a strained flag. "Why, of course," the druggist said. "If that's what you want. But the law requires you to tell what you are going to use it for."

155 Miss Emily just stared at him, her head tilted back in order to look him eye for eye, until he looked away and went and got the arsenic and wrapped it up. The Negro delivery boy brought her the package; the druggist didn't come back. When she opened the package at home there was written on the box, under the skull and bones: "For rats."

IV

So THE NEXT day we all said, "She will kill herself"; and we said it would be the best thing. When she had first begun to be seen with Homer Barron, we had said, "She will marry him."
160 Then we said, "She will persuade him yet," because Homer himself had remarked—he liked men, and it was known that he drank with the younger men in the Elks' Club—that he was not a marrying man. Later we said, "Poor Emily" behind the jalousies as they passed on Sunday afternoon in the glittering buggy, Miss Emily with her head high and Homer Barron with his hat cocked and a cigar in his teeth, reins and whip in a yellow glove.

165 Then some of the ladies began to say that it was a disgrace to the town and a bad example to the young people. The men did not want to interfere, but at last the ladies forced the Baptist

minister—Miss Emily's people were Episcopal— to call upon her. He would never divulge what happened during that interview, but he refused to go back again. The next Sunday
170 they again drove about the streets, and the following day the minister's wife wrote to Miss Emily's relations in Alabama.

So she had blood-kin under her roof again and we sat back to watch developments. At first nothing happened. Then we were sure that they were to be married. We learned that Miss Emily had been to the jeweler's and ordered a man's toilet set in silver, with the letters H.
175 B. on each piece. Two days later we learned that she had bought a complete outfit of men's clothing, including a nightshirt, and we said, "They are married." We were really glad. We were glad because the two female cousins were even more Grierson than Miss Emily had ever been.

So we were not surprised when Homer Barron—the streets had been finished some time since—was gone. We were a little disappointed that there was not a public blowing-off, but we believed that he had gone on to prepare for Miss Emily's coming, or to give her a chance to get rid of the cousins. (By that time it was a cabal, and we were all Miss Emily's allies to help circumvent the cousins.) Sure enough, after another week they departed. And, as we had expected all along, within three days Homer Barron was back in town. A neighbor saw
185 the Negro man admit him at the kitchen door at dusk one evening.

And that was the last we saw of Homer Barron. And of Miss Emily for some time. The Negro man went in and out with the market basket, but the front door remained closed. Now and then we would see her at a window for a moment, as the men did that night when they sprinkled the lime, but for almost six months she did not appear on the streets. Then
190 we knew that this was to be expected too; as if that quality of her father which had thwarted her woman's life so many times had been too virulent and too furious to die.

When we next saw Miss Emily, she had grown fat and her hair was turning gray. During the next few years it grew grayer and grayer until it attained an even pepper-and-salt iron-gray, when it ceased turning. Up to the day of her death at seventy-four it was still that vigorous
195 iron-gray, like the hair of an active man.

From that time on her front door remained closed, save for a period of six or seven years, when she was about forty, during which she gave lessons in china-painting. She fitted up a studio in one of the downstairs rooms, where the daughters and granddaughters of Colonel Sartoris' contemporaries were sent to her with the same regularity and in the same spirit that
200 they were sent to church on Sundays with a twenty-five-cent piece for the collection plate. Meanwhile her taxes had been remitted.

Then the newer generation became the backbone and the spirit of the town, and the painting pupils grew up and fell away and did not send their children to her with boxes of color and tedious brushes and pictures cut from the ladies' magazines. The front door closed upon the
205 last one and remained closed for good. When the town got free postal delivery, Miss Emily alone refused to let them fasten the metal numbers above her door and attach a mailbox to it. She would not listen to them.

Daily, monthly, yearly we watched the Negro grow grayer and more stooped, going in and out with the market basket. Each December we sent her a tax notice, which would be returned
210 by the post office a week later, unclaimed. Now and then we would see her in one of the downstairs windows—she had evidently shut up the top floor of the house—like the carved torso of an idol in a niche, looking or not looking at us, we could never tell which. Thus she passed from generation to generation—dear, inescapable, impervious, tranquil, and perverse.

And so she died. Fell ill in the house filled with dust and shadows, with only a doddering
215 Negro man to wait on her. We did not even know she was sick; we had long since given up
trying to get any information from the Negro

He talked to no one, probably not even to her, for his voice had grown harsh and rusty, as if
from disuse.

She died in one of the downstairs rooms, in a heavy walnut bed with a curtain, her gray head
220 propped on a pillow yellow and moldy with age and lack of sunlight.

V

THE NEGRO met the first of the ladies at the front door and let them in, with their hushed,
sibilant voices and their quick, curious glances, and then he disappeared. He walked right
through the house and out the back and was not seen again.

225 The two female cousins came at once. They held the funeral on the second day, with the town
coming to look at Miss Emily beneath a mass of bought flowers, with the crayon face of her
father musing profoundly above the bier and the ladies sibilant and macabre; and the very
old men –some in their brushed Confederate uniforms–on the porch and the lawn, talking
of Miss Emily as if she had been a contemporary of theirs, believing that they had danced
230 with her and courted her perhaps, confusing time with its mathematical progression, as the
old do, to whom all the past is not a diminishing road but, instead, a huge meadow which
no winter ever quite touches, divided from them now by the narrow bottle-neck of the most
recent decade of years.

Already we knew that there was one room in that region above stairs which no one had seen
235 in forty years, and which would have to be forced. They waited until Miss Emily was decently
in the ground before they opened it.

The violence of breaking down the door seemed to fill this room with pervading dust. A thin,
acrid pall as of the tomb seemed to lie everywhere upon this room decked and furnished as
for a bridal: upon the valance curtains of faded rose color, upon the rose-shaded lights, upon
240 the dressing table, upon the delicate array of crystal and the man's toilet things backed with
tarnished silver, silver so tarnished that the monogram was obscured. Among them lay a
collar and tie, as if they had just been removed, which, lifted, left upon the surface a pale
crescent in the dust. Upon a chair hung the suit, carefully folded; beneath it the two mute
shoes and the discarded socks.

245 The man himself lay in the bed.

For a long while we just stood there, looking down at the profound and fleshless grin. The
body had apparently once lain in the attitude of an embrace, but now the long sleep that
outlasts love, that conquers even the grimace of love, had cuckolded him. What was left of
him, rotted beneath what was left of the nightshirt, had become inextricable from the bed
250 in which he lay; and upon him and upon the pillow beside him lay that even coating of the
patient and biding dust.

Then we noticed that in the second pillow was the indentation of a head. One of us lifted
something from it, and leaning forward, that faint and invisible dust dry and acrid in the
nostrils, we saw a long strand of iron-gray hair.

255 Glossary

	affection		<i>subs.</i> hengivenhed
	encroached		<i>verb</i> trængte ind på
	obliterated		<i>verb</i> udslettede
	august		<i>adj.</i> fornem
260	coquettish		<i>adj.</i> koket
	hereditary		<i>adj.</i> arvelig
	edict		<i>subs.</i> dekret
	dispensation		<i>subs.</i> fritagelse
	perpetuity		<i>subs.</i> evighed
265	archaic		<i>adj.</i> gammeldags
	deputation		<i>subs.</i> delegation
	dank		<i>adj.</i> fugtig
	tarnished		<i>adj.</i> anløben
	errand		<i>subs.</i> ærinde
270	temerity		<i>subs.</i> dumdristighed
	diffident		<i>adj.</i> tilbageholdende
	deprecation		<i>subs.</i> undskyldende modvilje
	slunk		<i>verb</i> sneg sig
	tableau		<i>subs.</i> opstilling
275	spraddled		<i>adj.</i> bredbenet
	vindicated		<i>verb</i> retfærdiggjort
	condolence		<i>subs.</i> kondolence
	serene		<i>adj.</i> afklaret
	jalousies		<i>subs.</i> skodder
280	impervious		<i>adj.</i> upåvirkelig
	haughty		<i>adj.</i> hovmodig
	cabal		
	circumvent		
	sibilant		
285	inextricable		